



FAMILY COURT DATA REPORT · STATE SERIES · NO. 23

MICHIGAN

WHAT FAMILIES ARE REPORTING.

Pulled from the Family Rights Registry — the first cross-state dataset on what pro se parents are actually experiencing inside Michigan's family courts and child-welfare system.

80

MICHIGAN FAMILIES ON RECORD · 92
CHILDREN IMPACTED · 16 MONTHS
MEDIAN MONTHS LOST OF PARENTING
TIME

REPORT GENERATED
APRIL 26, 2026

COUNTIES REPRESENTED
32 OF 83

COMPILED BY
MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

THE HEADLINE NUMBERS

MICHIGAN AT A GLANCE.

Across 80 Michigan families reporting through the Family Rights Registry, the patterns are consistent: long durations in court, serious financial loss, and a disproportionate number of parents going unrepresented because they ran out of money fighting.

CHILDREN IMPACTED 92 79 of 80 families reported child counts	MEDIAN ATTORNEY FEES \$18,000 per reporting family	MEDIAN MONTHS LOST 16 of parenting time	WENT PRO SE 48.8% 42.5% after running out of money
SUBMISSIONS 80	AVG CHILDREN / FAMILY 1.2	FAMILIES REPORTING CHILDREN 79 of 80	COUNTIES REPRESENTED 32

WHY THIS REPORT EXISTS.

On January 29, 2024, I lost custody of all five of my children.

- NO TRIAL.
- NO QUESTIONING.
- NO SUBSTANTIATED ABUSE.

It took only a signature on an ex parte emergency order to erase a mother. I refused to disappear. I fought back, and built the Family Rights Registry so Michigan families — and families in every state — would stop being invisible to the data. This report is their record.

— MEG · [STANDWITHMEG.COM](https://standwithmeg.com)

02 THE COST OF MICHIGAN FAMILY COURT

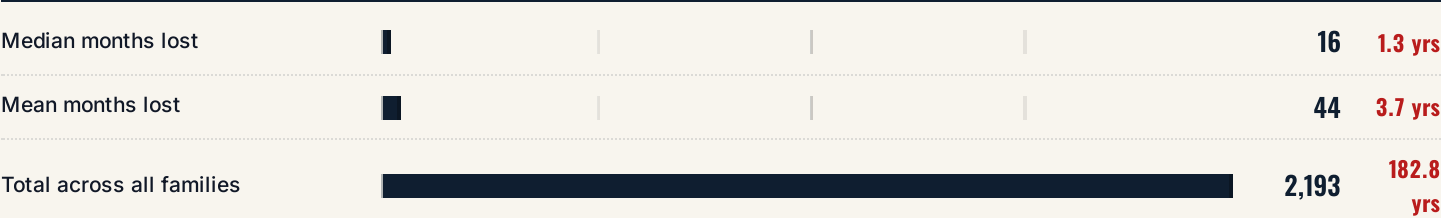
Legal fees are the largest reported expense, but they are not the only one. Lost wages, evaluation costs, and reunification services compound the financial loss — pushing most families toward pro se representation once their savings run out.

EXPENSE CATEGORY	RESPONSES	MEDIAN	MEAN	TOTAL REPORTED
Attorney Fees	49	\$18,000	\$63,939	\$3,133,000
Lost Wages	39	\$10,000	\$72,500	\$2,827,500
Other Court Fees	29	\$750	\$23,943	\$694,351
Therapy / Evaluations	33	\$1,500	\$7,319	\$241,531
Reunification Services	29	\$1	\$5,929	\$171,951
GAL Fees	29	\$0	\$6,200	\$179,801
Asset Loss ¹	38	\$40,000	—	—
Estimated Median Family Impact	—	\$70,251	—	—

Median vs. mean: Median is the middle reported amount, so it better reflects the typical reporting family when a few very large expenses appear. Mean is the average across reporting families and can be pulled higher by outliers.

1. On asset loss: One respondent reported an extreme outlier that skews the mean beyond usefulness. We report the median (\$40,000) and suppress the mean and total, pending data-quality review. Lost Wages also contains wide variance; median is the honest headline.

LOST PARENTING TIME · MONTHS



03 WHO IS REPORTING · MICHIGAN

Most families documenting in Michigan are currently active in, or recently closed out of, long-running cases. Nearly half have lost all contact with their children.

CASE STATUS · SYSTEM AFFECTED

CASE STATUS

Active case: stuck or delayed		42	52%
Not provided		24	30%
Case closed: more than 2 years ago		7	9%
Case closed: within last 2 years		5	6%
I am not currently in court but still affected		1	1%

SYSTEM AFFECTED

Both Family Court and CPS		37	46%
Family Court Only		26	32%
Unknown		10	12%
CPS (Child Protective Services) Only		6	8%
Child Protective Services (CPS / DCF)		1	1%

DURATION · CUSTODY OUTCOMES

TIME IN SYSTEM

1 – 3 years		19	24%
Over 10 years		15	19%
5 – 10 years		12	15%
3 – 5 years		10	12%
6 months – 1 year		9	11%

CUSTODY STATUS

No Contact / Total Loss of Access		19	24%
Visitation Only		15	19%
Children in Foster Care		12	15%
50/50 Joint		11	14%
Adopted Out (Rights Terminated)		9	11%

GEOGRAPHY · ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

TOP COUNTIES

Oakland		8	10%
Wayne		7	9%
Macomb		3	4%
Kalamazoo		3	4%
Kent		3	4%
Washtenaw		2	2%

TOP ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

Family Court False Accusations (Domestic Violence/Abuse/Alienation)		21	26%
False Accusations CPS (Non-Medical) (Vengeful ex-partner, malicious report)		14	18%
Other: (Short answer)		13	16%
Medical CPS (Medical Child Abuse allegations, disagreement with doctors)		7	9%
Environmental/Poverty-Related (Lack of housing, utilities, etc.)		4	5%

05 PARENT VOICES — MICHIGAN

Quotes appear as submitted. Long submissions are trimmed with [...] to fit the page; the full unedited quote is available in the online version of this report.



They stole my children and gave my ex sole physical and legal custody. No convictions or abuse allegations or charges. NO CPS involvement

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

ON THE REPORTED ALLEGATIONS

Traumatized my children, which led to psychological behaviors occurring after removal, depriving me of the right to visitation only allowing my husband to visit our children for 3 months when this case first opened, due process violations, destroyed my childrens bond with their [...]

— MICHIGAN PARENT · KIRSTIE

MORE VOICES FROM MICHIGAN

Destroyed the fabric of my family and my whole existence! 5 children ripped from their mother!

— AMYJO

Ripped us apart and traumatized my children

— SIERRA

Ripped my family in half. Sold two kids to abusers Jason and Jessica Klimp.

— STACY

My husband recorded my daughter through the bathroom window at my home. I called Ashley child advocacy center and also took her for a forensic interview. At that time we both did a police interview. I picked up my husband after work and took him to turn in his phone and [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Destroyed normalcy for our children Not listened to the children Traumatized us Taken all our money

— LAUREN

The system has traumatized us, used us, abused us, ignored us, and tried to break down our mental well-being.

— STACEY

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



It has stolen our time and destroyed our belief in this country, while it shattered our voices leaving us to pick up the pieces.

— STACI

The CPS supervisor lied and medically kidnapped both of my grandchildren because she has a vendetta against disabled veteran families

— TERI

in suspending my parenting time for "risk of harm" they created ongoing and irreparable harm to my children. The judgement of divorce which was meant to stabilize my children's lives was dismantled by a GAL with unchecked authority, a loophole in the legal system to punish and [...]

— AMANDA

<https://voiceofdetroit.net/2016/05/01/hearing-on-disabled-abused-child-may-2-why-does-judge-martha-snow-endanger-janna-jail-mom/>

— SHANNON (DEBACKER)

If I were to describe what is being done to these children and families in the system in one word, it would be torture

— SYDNEY

This system did not just break apart my marriage, it destabilized my entire family by turning loss into years of financial pressure, legal battles, and emotional damage. It has strained my relationship with my children, stripped away stability, and made rebuilding feel like [...]

— PAUL

The system enabled domestic violence and terror upon me and the kids and it severed my bond with my twins.

— STEPHANIE

They have failed us. Always gave the mother what she requested. Ignored emotional abuse to the children.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Emotional strain , separation between siblings in the home, cost me my job ,my rights .

— DAVID

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



Raped me of the opportunity to be a mother & Deprived my children of growing up with a mom, and made me cold and dead behind the eyes.

— CHRISTINA

Destroyed my family, lost my home and has ruined her siblings relationships

— DEAN

Erased my motherhood and all my children's loving memories

— BRANDEE

Completely destroyed my home, my life, my kids and family irreparably

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system did not benefit our family in any way because they medically kidnapped my granddaughter on false allegations and coercion! We are a disabled veteran household with autism in our family history and CPS used everything against us without proof!

— TERI

Gave me PTSD, financial drain, depression, anxiety, and psychological trauma to my minor children

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Denied me and my girls the right to speak for ourselves and only allowed the opinion of my wealthy ex to speak and make false allegations.

— LESLIE

My son's mom basically kidnapped my son, moved about six states away. Press false charges against me to keep me away from my son even longer so she would have full custody.. I went in to court with an attorney within 10 minutes I don't even know what happened it happened so fast [...]

— JOHN

The system didn't just fail to protect my children, it became part of the harm by rewarding delay, conflict, and procedure over stability and safety. Instead of reducing trauma, it created and prolonged it.

— KELLY

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED

*Evil trauma to my entire family*

— WILHELMINA

The system has failed my family, destroyed our lives and made me homeless.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Destroyed my family, our bonds. Ive lost everything more than once now Pain beyond measure..... I hate opening my eyes everyday knowing I have to live another day like this.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

It broke us physically and mentally. I'm advocating for my daughter Tichina Sanders. This is her story. Cps fabricated lies and the judge went along with it by not looking at her evidence.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

We will never get back what we lost.

— ROBERTA

Years of mistreatment and abuse from the system has caused major issues within my family.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

My three children are in therapy and have mental health issues on my side since the system I have agoraphobia I am scared to leave my house with ptsd. It has hurt the relationship between the three I lost and there five younger brothers.

— AMY

Navigating this process has placed prolonged emotional and financial strain on my family while we work toward reunification, stability, and a sense of normalcy for my children.

— MOLLY

I am bankrupt and hardly surviving, 8 years and I am financially ruined and every bit of savings and retirement gone. I thank god my children are safe with me-due to a violent attack and the other parent the attacker-family court is now forcing visits or jail for me. I am [...]

— KERRY

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



The system has literally made me terrified of being a parent.

— JOSHUA

Created years of psychological and emotional damage, financial damage

— MATT

It caused me such emotional harm and mental health issues

— CHRIS

The system has exploited my mental health crisis for funding, along with keeping their caseloads up.

— KAYC

The system has made my family estranged and kept my daughter's separated and my 5 year old isolated

— JENNIFER

This System Destroys families and tries to Ruin Family Bonds!

— DANIELLE

Raped, convicted, drained, and Murdered the future for the next generation of family.

— EMILY

More damage and a lifetime of trauma my kids and i will never overcome. I thought leaving a 11 year DV marriage was gonna be hard....just To have him get custody and my daughter in foster care. Now history repeats itself. Not because i chose to not be with my kids, because i was [...]

— RICOLE

I've been financially and emotionally destroyed by a system that overlooked evidence of harm to my child, dismissed my appeal, and continues to prevent fair, neutral review."

— AMY

Constant constitutional violations and extortion

— DAVID

I'm being set up to become a payer to the Title IV-D system. My ex made false allegations, sent multiple death threats and still has more custody than me. I make more money so guess who doesn't get to see their kid.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

58 Michigan parents submitted ranked quotes. 46 appear in this report; the remainder are available at standwithmeg.com/mi.

06 HOW TO READ THIS REPORT

WHAT THIS IS

The Family Rights Registry is a national, parent-reported data collection run by Stand With Meg. Every figure in this Michigan report comes from Michigan respondents who voluntarily submitted survey entries about their experience inside family court and/or CPS.

This report is built to help families, advocates, reporters, and legislators see the patterns emerging in Michigan — not to replace formal research, and not to name individual judges or counties as responsible parties.

WHAT IT ISN'T

This is not a representative sample. Respondents self-select. The 80 Michigan families reporting here are not the universe of Michigan families in court — they are the families who found the survey, trusted it enough to submit, and told us what happened to them.

Financial figures are self-reported. We flag outliers and report medians when means are distorted (see page 3, note 1). Quotes are minimally edited.

METHODOLOGY · FAMILY RIGHTS REGISTRY

Data in this report was collected April 2024 – April 2026 through standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey. Submissions are timestamped. Duplicate-submission heuristics use normalized email + location, with direct survey rows preferred over legacy rows and the newest row retained within each source. Categorical responses from multi-select and short-answer fields are normalized monthly.

When a respondent's financial entry differs from the population by more than three standard deviations, the mean is suppressed and only the median is reported. Lost-wage, attorney-fee, and asset-loss entries are self-reported and not corroborated against tax records or court filings.

Geographic reporting uses the county field as submitted, with light normalization (e.g. "Butte silverbow" → "Butte–Silver Bow"). Quotes carry one of three public permission states: *Anonymous*, *First-name only*, or *Full attribution with consent to public use*. Court actor names appear only after 5 independent families name the same actor.

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ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is based on self-reported survey submissions collected by Stand With Meg. Counts and categories reflect responses available at the time this packet was generated.

This report is for informational and advocacy use only, not legal advice or an official government record.

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